

U.S. Equity Insights

Pricing a capex supercycle

As AI investment scales to levels rivaling the capex supercycles of the 1990s and 2000s, we highlight EV/EBITDA as a valuation metric that gains signal strength over P/E, when evaluating medium-term investment horizons that coincide with elevated capex.

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Key Points & Highlights

- **Capex finds another gear.** Aggregate S&P 500 capex is projected to grow 40% Y/Y in 2026 and is on track to absorb roughly 50% of operating cash flows, levels that recall the supercycles of the 1990s and 2000s. Tech is dead center with TMT capex as a share of total S&P 500 capex projected to approach 50% this year, a step change even relative to the late-2010s public cloud buildout. History suggests that when capex intensity reaches these levels, even good investment can overshoot, raising the question of how much to pay for marginal return on invested capital.
- **EV/EBITDA gains signal strength over medium-term horizons when capex is elevated.** Over the last 30 years, EV/EBITDA exhibited a stronger linear relationship with S&P 500 forward 3Y total return (based on quintile sorting of the metric and cheap-expensive spread) when compared to P/E, during periods of high capex. This supports the intuitive framing that EV/EBITDA more closely reflects what investors are paying for the operating asset base, over an investment horizon that better aligns with a typical capex cycle.

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- **We remain constructive near-term.** This valuation signal has limited timing power over shorter periods, and it's worth noting that currently-elevated EV/EBITDA is being shaped as much by the beneficiaries of AI capex as by the companies undertaking the spending itself. Meanwhile, the NTM earnings backdrop remains supportive, particularly within the broader Tech complex. Taken together, elevated capex and EV/EBITDA argue for investors with a multi-year horizon to look at entry points with greater selectivity, while the combination of rising EPS estimates and strong secular growth leaves the near-term setup constructive.

FIGURE 1. Barclays 2026 Year-End Estimates for S&P 500

Barclays S&P 500 FY 2026 Estimates					
Scenario	EPS	Growth (yoy)	PE Multiple	YE Value	Upside/Downside
Bull Case	\$327	17.6%	25.1x	8,200	7.8%
Base Case	\$321	15.5%	23.8x	7,650	0.5%
Bear Case	\$311	11.9%	18.5x	5,900	-22.5%
Current S&P 500 Price				7,610	

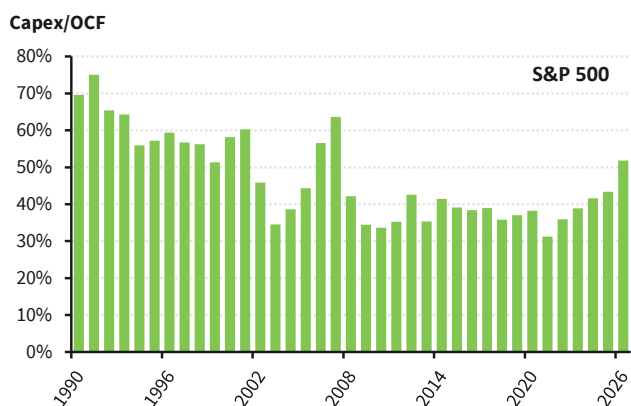
As of 3 June 2026.

Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

S&P 500 capex outlook vs. history

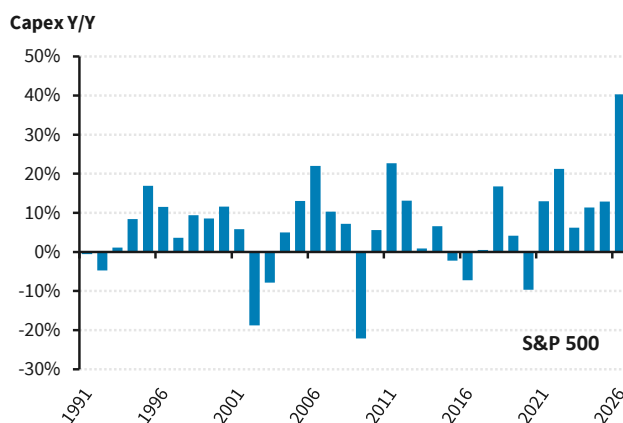
S&P 500 capex is on track to absorb roughly 50% of operating cash flows in 2026, a level that places this cycle squarely alongside prior capex supercycles like the mid-to-late 1990s telecom/internet buildout and the mid-2000s energy and housing investment boom. While the 1990s featured record equipment spending by telecom carriers and OEMs, and the mid-2000s cycle was broader and more industrial in nature, in both cases capex ultimately proved both productivity-enhancing and value-destructive, with long-dated payoffs that followed a period of painful consolidation.

FIGURE 2. S&P 500 capex is on track to absorb 50% of operating cash flow in 2026



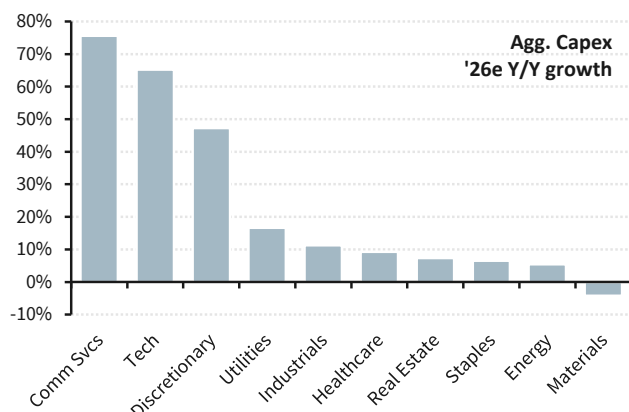
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 3. Aggregate capex is projected to increase 40% Y/Y, the fastest pace in at least 35 years

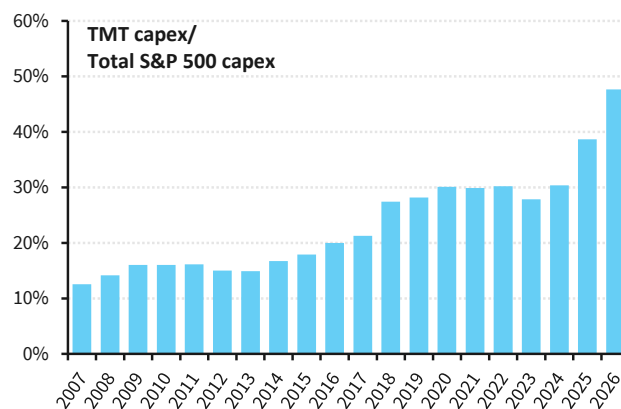


Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

What distinguishes the current cycle is not simply its scale, but its concentration. Aggregate S&P 500 capex is expected to grow roughly 40% Y/Y, the fastest pace in at least 35 years, yet the bulk of that growth is coming from Communication Services, Tech and Discretionary; effectively the AI hyperscalers, chipmakers, and their immediate supply chains. TMT capex as a share of total S&P 500 capex is projected to approach 50% this year, a step change even relative to the late-2010s public cloud buildout. History suggests that when capex intensity reaches these levels, even good investment can overshoot, raising the question of how much to pay for marginal return on invested capital.

FIGURE 4. Most of the Y/Y capex growth is coming from hyperscaler sectors

Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

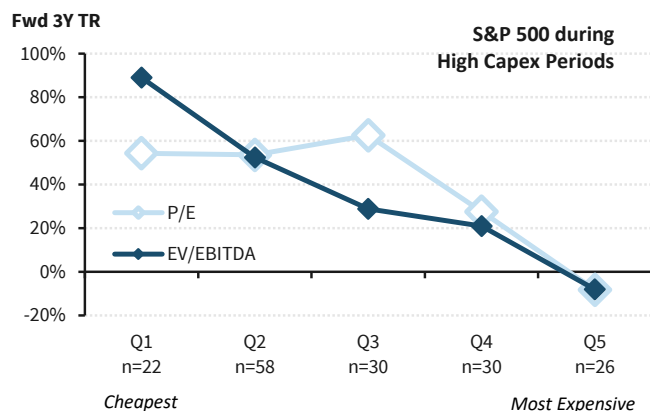
FIGURE 5. TMT capex as a share of total S&P 500 capex is projected to approach 50% this year, an ATH

Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

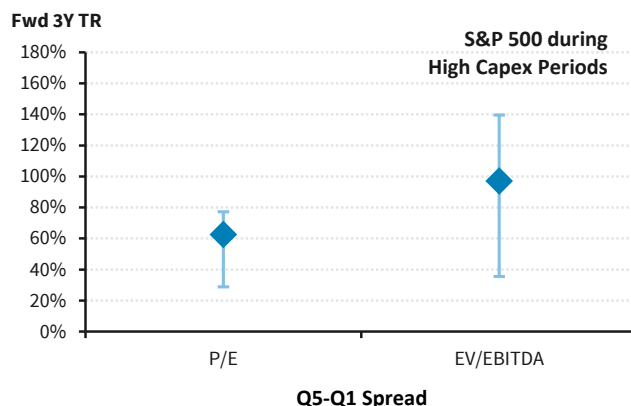
EV/EBITDA as a check against P/E during elevated capex

When capex intensity rises, valuation signals can migrate up the income statement as P/E becomes vulnerable to nonlinear distortions from leverage, tax shields, and depreciation policies. EV/EBITDA has its own limitations but can be useful as a check against P/E, as it more directly reflects what investors are paying for the operating asset base. Given the multi-year timeline typical of a capex supercycle, EV/EBITDA can also align better with returns at a comparable horizon by focusing on enterprise-level metrics (including financing of the capex).

We find some empirical evidence to support this. During capex-heavy regimes since the mid-1990s, EV/EBITDA sorting exhibits a stronger relationship with medium-term returns, with forward 3Y S&P 500 total returns declining monotonically from the cheapest to the richest quintile. The same monotonicity breaks down for P/E, where mid-quintiles tend to outperform the tails, suggesting that P/E embeds cycle-specific convexities to a greater degree. Consistent with this, the cheap-expensive return spread delivered by EV/EBITDA sorting appears wider than P/E during these periods, which we believe supports EV/EBITDA as a more linear check on expected medium-term returns.

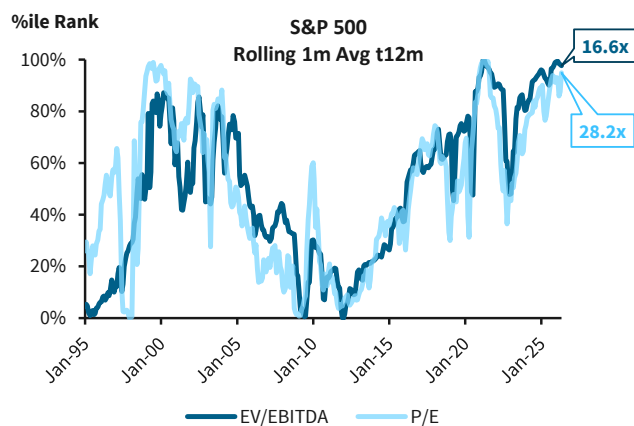
FIGURE 6. During high capex periods, EV/EBITDA exhibits a stronger linear relationship with forward 3Y total return compared to P/E

"High capex" defined as t12m Capex/EBITDA above the 50th percentile of monthly observations (n) since 1995.
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

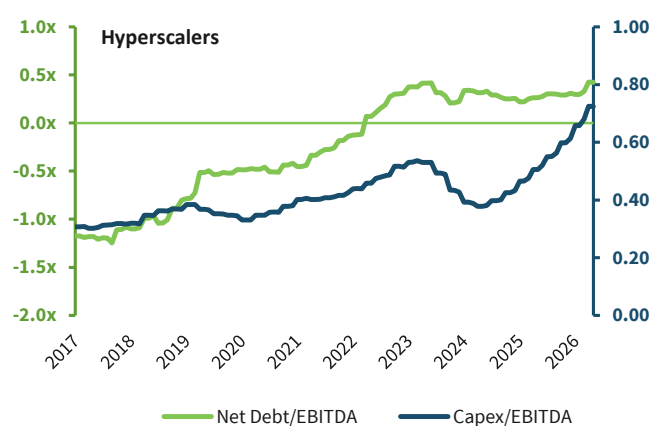
FIGURE 7. EV/EBITDA sorting delivers larger cheap-expensive 3Y return spread than P/E during high capex periods

"High capex" defined as t12m Capex/EBITDA above the 50th percentile of monthly observations since 1995. Error bars = 95% CI.
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

This framing matters for today because S&P 500 EV/EBITDA is currently more elevated than P/E, when compared to its own long-run history. As with past capex booms, today's massive spending on compute coincides with optimistic narratives about long-run growth, which can sustain high headline multiples even as worries about over-investment begin to rise. And while consensus estimates call for a deceleration in spending growth sometime in 2027 or 2028, elevated enterprise values leave less scope for multiple expansion once capex normalizes, placing the burden on future earnings to drive additional upside.

FIGURE 8. T12M EV/EBITDA is more elevated than P/E when compared to its own history

Data as of 31 May 2026.
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 9. Hyperscalers are redeploying balance sheets as capex commitments rise

Data as of 31 May 2026.
Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

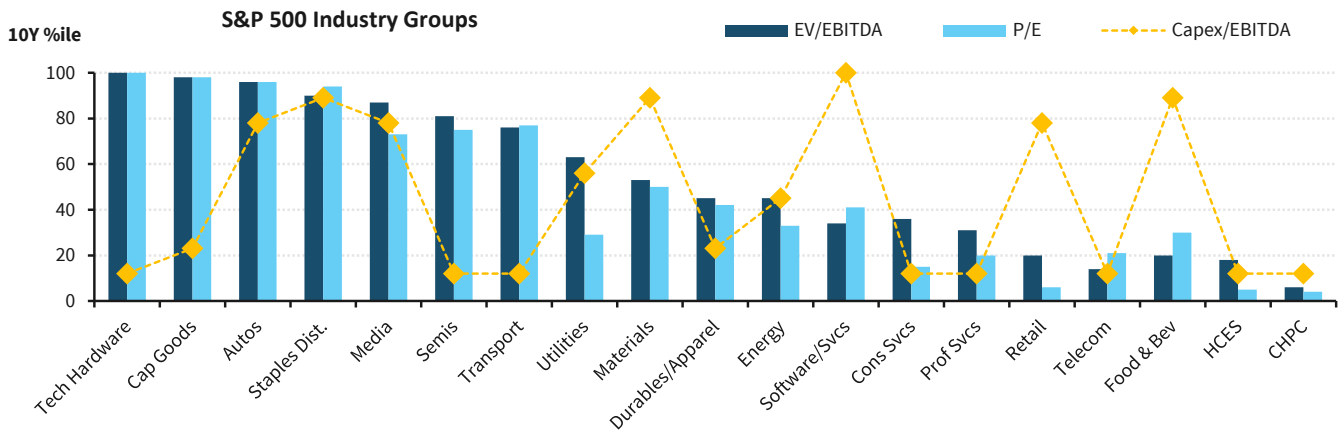
Matching valuation to investment horizon

This is not to say that that we are taking a negative view on US equities over the next 12 months. We found the EV/EBITDA signal to be inherently medium-term in nature with limited timing power over shorter horizons, including one year or less, where the relationship with forward

returns was much less significant. Moreover, capex peaks tended to coincide with late-cycle dynamics historically, which are more consequential at multi-year horizons. Finally, we'd point out that currently elevated valuations are being shaped as much by the beneficiaries of AI capex (such as Tech Hardware, Capital Goods and Semis) as by the companies undertaking the spending itself.

The NTM earnings backdrop remains supportive, particularly within the broader Tech complex, and valuations have yet to retake recent median levels. Taken together, elevated capex and EV/EBITDA argue for investors with a multi-year horizon to look at entry points with greater selectivity, while the combination of rising EPS expectations, recent valuation trends and strong secular growth leaves the near-term setup constructive.

FIGURE 10. 10Y percentile rank of current EV/EBITDA, P/E and Capex/EBITDA by Industry Group



Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

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